

Introduction

Publishing is the process of making content accessible to the public in both print and digital forms (The National Archives, 2019). Traditional publishing has been increasingly challenged in recent years with the emergence of e-books. Suarez and Woudhuysen (2013) defined e-books as “a text-, acoustic-, and image-based publication in digital form produced on, published by means of, and readable on computers or other digital devices.” They appear in different forms, such as audiobooks, website-based content, and platform-based publishing.

The influence of e-books is not uniform across all publishing sectors, as each sector operates with different audiences, formats, and purposes. This essay focuses on the trade publishing sector, specifically children's trade publishing, which refers to books produced for general reading and entertainment rather than educational use (Shelanne Wolf, 2011). This sector is particularly important because early reading plays a key role in children's literacy development (Shamir and Korat, 2007), making it a relevant area for examining how technological changes may influence reading practices. Within this broader transition towards digital publishing, mobile and tablet devices have had a particularly significant influence, supported by a range of commercial models, including single-purchase, subscription-based, freemium applications and others (Berglund and Tanderup Linkis, 2022). Thus, the discussion is limited to the impact of mobile and tablet devices, such as smartphones and touchscreen tablets.

The main impact of mobile and tablet devices on the children's trade sector discussed in this essay is the transformation of children's books from static reading objects into multimodal, interactive digital experiences. Based on this argument, this essay will examine how this

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impact is reflected in changes to the form of children's books, their reading experience, and the reshaping of the competitive landscape of children's publishing, while also considering the advantages and limitations of this transformation through innovative examples of digital children's publishing.

Changes in the form of the children's book

From page-based object to screen-based experience

E-books on mobile devices have significant potential to expand children's access to reading by providing low-cost, diverse materials, thereby increasing both reading choice and volume (Suarez and Woudhuysen, 2013). Using Amazon Kindle as an example, it exists in two main forms: the Kindle tablet device and the Kindle application. Both allow users to store numerous books in one place, overcoming the physical limitations of printed books.

For children's publishing, this shift is not only about convenience or storage, but also about how the book is organised as a reading environment (Acheson, Barratt and Balthazor, 2013).

In traditional children's publishing, books are fixed and self-contained, with content presented in a stable format that remains unchanged throughout reading. Children engage with the text as a complete and structured object. In contrast, Kindle devices and applications are screen-based environments that allow readers to interact with the text more flexibly (Kenner, 2015). Children can adjust text size, navigate content more freely, and highlight or annotate directly within the interface. Thus, with devices like the Kindle, reading is no longer limited to a fixed object but becomes a more adaptable and interactive process.

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However, Kindle represents only a basic form of digital transformation, reproducing printed books in digital form (Thompson, 2021a). Children's publishing often demonstrates greater innovation, as early reading plays a key role in development (Shamir and Korat, 2007), and the needs of its audience vary significantly across different age groups (Wolf, 2011). As will be discussed later in this essay, more innovative examples of children's books on mobile and tablet devices further extend these possibilities.

Multimodality became central rather than supplementary

Multimodal reading and writing are defined as "the increasing complexity and inter-relationship of different modes of meaning", combining elements such as text, image, audio, and visual design (New London Group, 1996, p.78). Many scholars argue that, in most traditional print publishing, images are often seen as decoration or supplementary to the text rather than central to meaning-making (Alvermann, Unrau, and Ruddell, 2013). However, in mobile and tablet reading environments, multimodality has become a core aspect of the reading experience (Rowse, 2013). Features such as embedded audio, animation, and interactive elements help children engage more fully with stories.

In children's publishing, this shift is especially significant, as meaningful images are always vital in children's books to support understanding, particularly for young readers who are still developing literacy skills (Unsworth and Wheeler, 2002). On mobile and tablet devices, this visual support is extended through additional elements such as narration, sound effects, animation, and touch-based interaction. Research suggests that for pre-school children, visual stimulation can be more effective than listening alone in supporting engagement and understanding (Hayes and Birnbaum, 1980). A clear example of this is Vooks, a subscription-based children's reading app that presents storytelling books in animated form (Vooks,

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2026b). Rather than relying solely on text and static images, Vooks convey stories through animated visuals and audio narrated by professional voice actors. They aim to create a more immersive environment for children in which reading combines listening and interaction, rather than being limited to decoding written language.

However, the increased use of multimodal features does not necessarily lead to better reading outcomes. Although younger children may benefit from audio and visual support that helps them understand stories before they can read independently (Nasser, 2010), there are also some limitations.

While mobile and tablet devices enable visual and auditory input, they may reduce children's physical engagement. Research suggests that tactile engagement contributes to how children perceive and understand the world, and that reduced physical interaction may lead to "attentional deficits" later in life (Ardiel and Rankin, 2010). While digital books increase certain forms of engagement, they may also remove other forms that are equally important for early development. As shown in Figure 1, the tactile book "The Touch Me Book" includes various textured surfaces and materials to allow children to explore and feel the differences, not just through written descriptions. This type of book allows children to engage not only visually, but also physically, supporting sensory development alongside narrative understanding. In comparison, interaction on tablets is largely limited to tapping and swiping on a flat screen, which cannot replicate the same three-dimensional or textural experience. This suggests that the multimodal experience offered by mobile devices is not equivalent to the sensory experience of physical books but is instead more limited to visual and auditory modes. The transformation of children's books into multimodal digital experiences does not necessarily mean a fuller form of engagement, but rather a shift in the types of engagement that are prioritised. While digital formats enhance interaction through screens, they may

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simultaneously reduce opportunities for embodied and sensory exploration, which are important in early childhood development. Therefore, the impact of mobile and tablet devices extends beyond expanding how children interact with books to reshape what counts as “interaction” in children’s reading.

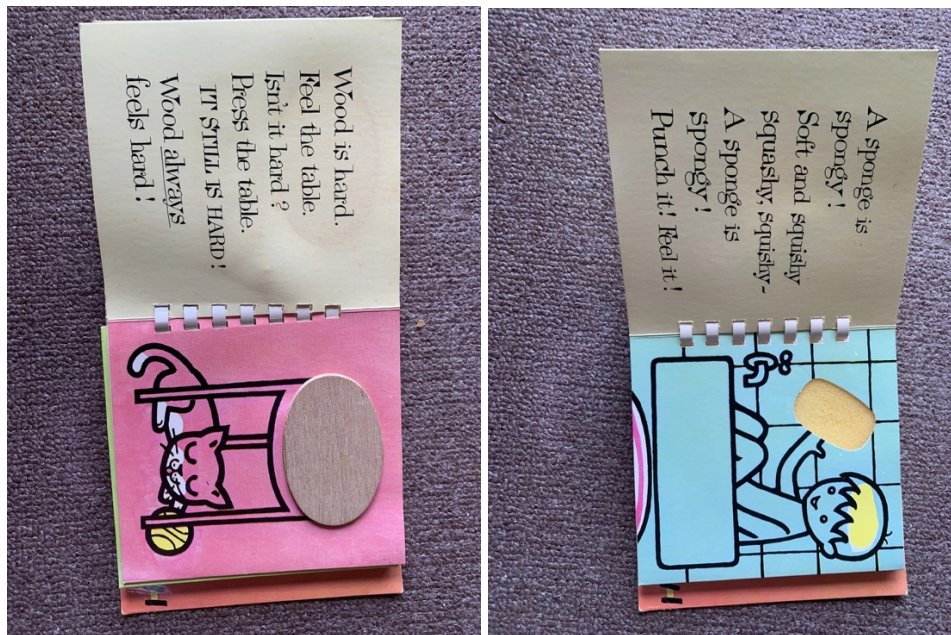


Figure 1: The Touch Me Book (Ebay, 2024)

Besides, the reading process is no longer centred on the child and the book but is increasingly influenced by the platform itself. The device has become an active participant in storytelling, managing the pace, tone, and sequence of the reading experience (Djonov, Tseng and Lim, 2021). This suggests that reading is no longer fully controlled by the reader but is partially guided and structured by the platform's design. Therefore, the transformation of children’s books into multimodal and interactive digital experiences also involves a shift in control, from the child as an active reader to the platform as a mediator of the reading process.

While multimodal and interactive features can help children understand stories more easily, they may also limit imagination. Martin (2023) indicates that reading is more effective than

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image-based activities such as television for developing imagination and creativity, as it encourages children to generate their own mental images. In printed books, children are often required to construct mental images based on textual and visual cues, which supports imaginative engagement. However, when sound, animation, and visual elements are fully provided, the narrative is more explicitly presented, leaving less room for children to interpret and imagine the story independently. As a result, although interactive features enhance accessibility and guidance, they may also shift reading from an imaginative process to a more passive experience.

Moreover, the consistency between stories and multimodality is essential. As Kucirkova (2019) points out, the value of digital books is not determined solely by the presence of multimedia and interactive features, but by whether these features can support children's understanding in meaningful ways. When audio, animation, or interactive elements are not aligned with or support the narrative, they can distract children and interrupt comprehension (Bus, Takacs and Kegel, 2015). This suggests that transforming children's books into multimodal, interactive digital experiences does not automatically lead to improved reading but rather depends on how these elements are designed and integrated. Thus, if multimedia elements are poorly integrated, they may hinder children's reading experience rather than support it.

Overall, although multimodality on mobile and tablet devices introduces new possibilities for interaction and enhances visual and auditory engagement, it may not be as effective as traditional children's books at fostering imagination and creativity. At the same time, it does not fully replace the sensory richness of innovative physical books such as "The Touch Me Book". Moreover, whether multimedia is beneficial also depends on the quality and coherence of its design (Kucirkova, 2019).

Changes in children's reading experience

Reading became embedded in wider screen habits

As children's publishing has become more interactive and multimodal on mobile and tablet devices, reading is no longer experienced as a single, focused activity, but is increasingly embedded within a wider screen-based environment (Ronconi et al., 2024). Mobile devices have repositioned children from reading within a single-purpose object, such as a printed book, to engaging with reading as one activity among many on the same device. While some devices, such as the Amazon Kindle tablet, are primarily designed for reading, most digital children's books exist as applications alongside games, videos, and other forms of entertainment on multifunctional devices such as smartphones. In this sense, the device functions not only as a medium for reading but as a multifunctional platform in which reading must compete with other forms of content.

In print contexts, children's reading is relatively contained and less exposed to external interruptions. However, mobile reading is embedded within what has been described as an "attention economy", where different types of content compete for limited user attention (Davenport and Beck, 2001). When children are reading, notifications from the device can easily interrupt their reading (Fox, Rosen and Crawford, 2009). Also, due to the screen interaction, when children click or scroll, they might accidentally close or switch applications, which can also disrupt their reading experience. This has positioned children alongside highly stimulating digital content. Overall, while interactivity allows children to engage with content more actively, it also means that reading takes place within a system designed for constant interaction and switching. The same features that enable interaction

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also make sustained attention more difficult. Therefore, the impact of mobile and tablet devices is not only to make reading more interactive but also to situate it within a fragmented, interruptible environment, reshaping how reading is experienced.

Nevertheless, it is important not to assume that all forms of digital reading are inherently negative. Interactive and multimodal features can increase engagement and motivation, especially for reluctant readers (Thompson and Mcilnay, 2019). However, these benefits exist within a multifunctional device environment, where reading is only one activity among many. The same interactive features that allow children to engage with content, such as tapping and scrolling, may also lead to unintended switching between applications, which can easily disrupt attention. Addressing the issue of distraction, therefore, requires not only controlling notifications but also managing how children interact with the device as a whole. For instance, parents can turn on focus modes such as "Do Not Disturb" on Apple iPad or similar settings on other devices, which can limit interruptions during reading. Therefore, the impact of mobile reading is not fixed, but depends on how the digital environment is managed.

Interactive and Gamified Reading Experience

Many children's reading applications have adopted elements of gamification to stimulate engagement and interest in reading (Dichev and Dicheva, 2017). These applications introduce gamified features such as earning rewards, upgrading levels, and gaining points, which aim to make reading more enjoyable. Teach Your Monster is a gamified reading application designed for early readers. The platform presents reading as a game-like journey (Teach Your Monster, 2026), where children solve puzzles and complete challenges based on their understanding of the story. In Teach Your Monster, reading is not a standalone activity but is embedded in a structured system of goals and rewards that encourages children to continue

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engaging with the text. Research shows that leisure-oriented reading can encourage children to genuinely enjoy reading rather than seeing it as an obligation (Wiesendanger, Braun, and Perry, 2026). This statement aligns with what Teach Your Monster claims to provide: reading is no longer perceived as work, but as entertainment.

Although gamified reading can increase enjoyment and short-term concentration, it also has limitations. Research suggests that gamified features and reward mechanisms may fail to develop children's "intrinsic motivation" (Hassan et al., 2019). This is because children may focus primarily on earning points or rewards rather than on the reading itself. Therefore, the satisfaction children gain from Teach Your Monster may come from completing game-like tasks rather than engaging with the narrative (Gurjanow et al., 2019). This can weaken the long-term sustainability of reading as a habit, as children may stop reading once these external rewards are removed (Sanchez, Langer, and Kaur, 2020).

In addition to sustainability, interactive and gamified features also affect memory and comprehension. Carr (2010) argues that digital reading may reduce deep concentration and affect memory retention compared to print reading. This is because fragmented attention makes it more difficult for readers to follow and retain narrative information over time. Similarly, Delgado et al. (2018) find that comprehension outcomes are often lower when reading on screens, particularly for longer or more complex texts. While these findings are based on general digital reading contexts, they are particularly relevant to children's gamified reading environments, where interaction and gameplay are more prominent. When children read from Teach Your Monster, they may remember more of the gaming experience rather than the narrative itself, as attention is often directed towards completing tasks or achieving rewards rather than following the story. In this sense, the interactive and gamified features discussed earlier may intensify the fragmented attention described by Carr (2010), making it

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more difficult for children to process and retain narrative content. This is particularly important because reading development relies heavily on sustained attention and repeated engagement with text (Chen and Lin, 2014).

Shared reading and independent reading were both reshaped

As most multimodal children's books include a read-aloud feature, parents' role in storytelling may be reduced. In traditional print settings, parents often guide their kids by reading aloud and explaining meanings, which creates a shared reading experience. However, in platforms such as Vooks, some of these roles are partly replaced by built-in narration. This can be convenient for parents and reduce the time required for active involvement (Sergi et al., 2017), which is also a selling point emphasised in Vooks' marketing (Vooks, 2026a).

However, this shift may reshape the nature of shared reading. While interactive features can support children's independent engagement, they may reduce direct interaction between parent and child, altering the social dimension of reading (Xu and Qiao, 2025). Scholars suggest that even when children are reading through applications, parents should still remain involved (Dias et al., 2016). This implies that the app should not replace parents, but rather support shared reading in a different way.

In practice, however, this may not always happen. Research has shown that even when parents read together with children, the more functions a digital children's book has, the less simulative language parents use while reading (Munzer et al., 2019). This phenomenon is critical because shared reading is not only about understanding the story, but also about language development and emotional bonding (Flack, Field and Horst, 2018). When interaction is reduced, children may receive less linguistic input and fewer opportunities for discussion, which are important for early literacy development (Shamir and Korat, 2007).

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Therefore, although interactive features promote independence, they may also weaken the social and communicative functions of reading if parental involvement is reduced too far.

Multimodality has reshaped competition in children's trade publishing

Books now compete with apps and films

Beyond changing the form of children's books and the reading experience, the multimodal and interactive features of mobile and tablet devices have widened the competitive landscape in children's publishing. In the traditional children's trade sector, competition primarily occurs among books, authors, and publishing companies, with a strong focus on the content of each book. However, the publishing environment is now far more competitive, as children's books are no longer competing only with other books but also with apps, games, and videos. As discussed in the previous section, children's reading has increasingly shifted from printed books to mobile phones and tablets, where books coexist with other forms of digital entertainment. As a result, reading is no longer separated from other activities, but must compete for children's time, attention, and spending within the same digital environment (Davenport and Beck, 2001).

This shift is especially important because many of these competing forms are easier to access than books. Although children's trade publishing platforms such as Vooks and Teach Your Monster are innovative, it is easy for users to find free alternatives on platforms such as YouTube. YouTube offers a large amount of free children's content, including animated storytelling and read-along videos (as shown in Figure 2). Unlike printed books, which generally require purchase before access, these forms of content are often instantly available

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and visually stimulating. Therefore, children's books are no longer competing only with other books, but also with a wider range of digital entertainment, in which free, highly accessible content has a clear advantage.

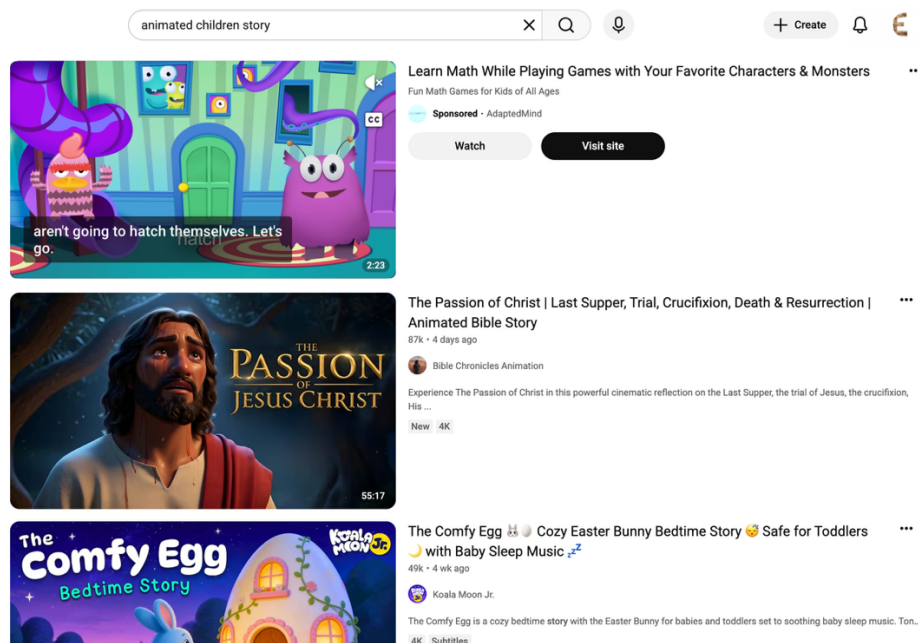


Figure 2: YouTube Search: Animated Children's Story (Youtube.com, 2026)

This can be understood as part of a longer development in media competition. When television first emerged, people increasingly saw it as a major competitor to books because it offered an alternative way to consume stories and information (Livingstone, 2003). In the current digital environment, however, the relationship has moved further. Streaming platforms and video-sharing platforms now take over much of this role, especially for children, whose media use is increasingly screen-based and platform-driven. More importantly, as children's books increasingly adopt animation, narration, and other multimedia elements, the boundary between books and other media forms becomes less clear. This can be understood in relation to Jenkins's (2006) concept of media convergence, in which content flows across different media platforms and formats. For this reason, films and

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animated series are not simply competitors to children's books – they may function as substitutes, offering similar narrative and sensory experiences (Dredge, 2017). If a child can access a free animated story on YouTube or a streaming platform, platforms such as Vooks may no longer compete as a separate reading medium but as one option among many forms of narrative entertainment. In this case, the key difference lies not in the type of experience offered, but in its cost and accessibility. When similar content is available for free and requires less effort to engage with, paid platforms such as Vooks may struggle to justify their value as a distinct product. This further suggests that the transformation of children's books into interactive and multimedia formats not only expands competition but also reduces the distinctiveness of digital books, making them more easily replaceable within a wider media environment.

Publishers were pushed to think beyond the book

The pressure to innovate in multimodal, interactive children's books requires publishers to think beyond the book's content, including how to attract children through interactive features and how to appeal to parents or schools as purchasers. This has shifted publishing from just producing text to creating an engaging reading experience.

This shift also requires wider collaboration beyond traditional publishing roles. For example, the development of digital children's books involves working with app developers, designers, and media producers to create applications and platforms. On Vooks' website, the platform highlights the use of professional voice actors and animators in producing its stories (Vooks, 2026b). They also have sound designers to combine audio elements to enhance the storytelling experience. These forms of production go beyond what is typically involved in printed books, which focus mainly on text and illustration.

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At the same time, children's publishing increasingly needs to consider cross-media distribution and presentation. Content is no longer confined to a single format, but can be adapted across apps, platforms, and other digital media (Newman, 2026). This means mobile devices have pushed children's trade publishing closer to a children's media business rather than keeping it in the traditional book publishing sector (Thompson, 2021b). Therefore, publishers are no longer competing only on the quality of their books, but also on their ability to design, produce, and distribute content across multiple media environments.

Conclusion

The primary impact of mobile and tablet devices on children's trade publishing, as discussed in this essay, has been the transformation of children's books from physical, static reading objects into multimodal, immersive, interactive digital formats. This essay has argued that this is not a series of separate changes, but a single transformation reflected across multiple aspects of children's publishing.

Firstly, children's books are no longer fixed, self-contained objects but are increasingly designed as interactive digital products. Multimodal features such as animation, sound, and touch-based interaction have become central rather than supplementary, which reshapes how stories are presented to children. However, this does not necessarily lead to a more complete reading experience, as it may reduce children's physical interaction with the book and imaginative interpretation.

Secondly, this transformation has significantly reshaped children's reading experience. While interactive and multimodal features can increase engagement and independent reading, they

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also place reading in a fragmented, platform-driven environment. This may shift reading from a focused and continuous activity to a guided one that can also be easily interrupted. In addition, the role of parents in shared reading may be replaced by its narrational function, potentially weakening the social and communicative aspects of reading.

Finally, multimodal content on mobile and tablet devices has expanded the competitive landscape of children's publishing. As books increasingly adopt multimedia features and resemble other media forms, such as movies, the boundary between publishing and digital entertainment has become less clear. Children's books are now competing with a wide range of digital media, including apps, videos, and streaming content. Thus, this may lead to substitution rather than simple competition, particularly when similar content is more accessible and often in free formats.

Overall, while mobile and tablet devices have introduced new possibilities for interaction and engagement in children's publishing, they have also reshaped the form of children's books, how reading is experienced and perceived, and the competitive landscape. The impact is therefore not simply that books have become more interactive, but that reading has been redefined within a broader digital media environment.